

[Return to Search](#)

Nyoro marriage and affinity

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All this sounds very advantageous to *muko*, but in fact his obligations to *isezara* are a good deal more onerous. He too must be properly dressed when he visits *isezara*, or when *isezara* visits him, and he must behave politely and respectfully to him. He should never visit *isezara* empty-handed, but should always bring a present of meat, salt, sugar, tobacco or cash. He should also buy clothes, perhaps a pair of trousers or a shirt, for *isezara* from time to time. He should help both of his parents-in-law 'like a real son'; this may involve assistance in bush-clearing, house-building, perhaps in the transport of produce to market. If *isezara* is ill *muko* may be expected to consult the diviners to find out what the matter is, and if there is a death in *isezara's* family he should attend the funeral, bringing a present of a barkcloth, nowadays a cotton cloth, for the shroud. When he visits *isezara* he must be careful not to speak of 'shameful things' (*by'ensoni*); that is, he must not make rude jokes or talk about sexual matters. He may not address his wife's father by his personal name (though his wife's father may so address him); he must address him by terms expressing their different statuses, such as *waitu*, *munyoro*, or *mukama wange* ('sir', 'lord', or 'my master'), or by his *mpako* or praise-name. He may not speak offensively to or argue with his *isezara*, and when he is in his parents-in-law's home he may not whistle or make any kind of loud noise. A good son-in-law should visit his *isezara's* home once in every two or three months. *Isezara* has no such reciprocal obligation. Banyoro say that *isezara* 'rules' *muko*, even when *isezara* is, as he may be, of the same generation as or even younger than *muko*, for it is proper for a father to rule his child. *Isezara* may 'fine' his son-in-law, for example if he is failing in respect, or maltreats his wife without sufficient cause. There are proverbs which express the inequality of the relationship between men and their wives' fathers. '*Isezara* is like the king' (*isezara nasisana Mukama*), Banyoro say; not only because, like him, he makes constant demands for goods and services which must be met, but also because, just as the king enriches people by

431
Gift Giving

476
Mutual Aid

5710

574
Visiting And
Hospitality

576
Etiquette

606
Parents-In-Law And
Children-In-Law

758
Medical Care

764
Burial Practices And
Funerals

giving them cattle, women, and land, so *isezara* has enriched *muko* by giving him a wife. More expressive still is the somewhat cynical '*isezara* is like the cavity under a termite mound' (*isezara nk'emrambya*). These cavities are said to be impossible to fill up, however much grass, earth, and brushwood are thrust down them. So it is with *isezara* and his continual demands for goods and services.

Less need be said of *muko*'s relations with *nyinazara*. The relationship is of the typical 'avoidance' pattern; *muko* may not see, eat with, or directly address his wife's mother, though he may send her polite messages and gifts and indeed is expected to do so. When *muko* visits his parents-in-law's house he greets *nyinzara* through a third person, even though she may be only a few feet away behind a thin mud and wattle partition, or just outside the door. However, as in some other societies, the stringency of this relationship, and indeed of the whole *buko* complex, decreases as time passes. Some months after the marriage there should be a formal exchange of visits between the  two households; first the parents-in-law visit their son-in-law's house, accompanied by numerous relations and friends and bringing gifts, and some time later the son-in-law and a party of his friends and relatives return the visit. These formal visits initiate a much more friendly and easy relationship between *muko* and his wife's people, but they do not eliminate the essential inequality of the relationship, which is transmitted even into *muko*'s relationship with *isezara*'s sons and with his son's sons, all of whom may be referred to as *isezara*.

574
Visiting And
Hospitality

576
Etiquette602
Kin Relationships

606
Parents-In-Law And
Children-In-Law

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